

Throwing RAM At The Problem

Q I'm assembling a PC with the following specifications:

- ☐ Intel Pentium D945 (3.4 GHz)
- ☐ Intel D965RY motherboard
- ☐ ViewSonic 17-inch TFT Monitor
- ☐ Kingston 1 GB DDR2 533 MHz RAM
- ☐ 320 GB Western Digital HDD
- ☐ 20x Lite-On DVD-Writer

I want a suitable graphics card at Rs 4,000 to 6,500, and have zeroed in on the Forza 7600GS which was featured in *Digit*, November 2006. Please give me a dealer address in Mumbai. Also, do I need a graphics card if I have 2 GB of DDR2 RAM instead of 1 GB?

Amit Puri

 Forza's 7600GS will cost about Rs 5,500 in Mumbai. Try Shree Sagarmatha Pvt Ltd, the official distributors for Forza cards in India. The number is 011-26428541, and I'm sure they'll be able to direct you to a dealer near you.

A graphics card is essential for a good multimedia PC, especially if you plan on gaming. This is regardless of the amount of RAM you have installed. If you are using integrated graphics instead of a graphics card, the more RAM the better, because system memory is utilised as graphics memory by the VGA controller.

A suggestion regarding the above system: I'd suggest you opt for a Core 2 Duo E6300 instead of the Pentium D CPU. The performance hike is well worth the premium—around Rs 2,500 more.

Double Whammy

Q I run an AMD64 3000+ (939) PC. My motherboard is an MSI RS480M2-IL, ATI Radeon x200 based. I'm looking to buy a graphics card in the Rs 4,000 to 5,000 range. I've heard about NVIDIA cards having issues with this chipset. Should I buy an ATI card in light of this? More importantly, my primary OS is Ubuntu Dapper 6.06. I also use Windows XP. Do ATI's drivers work well under Linux?

Sudhindra

 Your problem is two-pronged, Sudhindra! The MSI RS480M2-IL has issues with any NVIDIA graphics card, so you're left with ATI as an option. Now ATI has very bad driver support for Linux. There are both 32-bit and 64-bit drivers available, but they are buggy at best, especially since they are generic Linux drivers. I'm afraid you will not be able to use Ubuntu 6.06 as an OS unless you're prepared to change your motherboard and buy an NVIDIA card. Incidentally, NVIDIA's 7300GS and ATI's X1300 Pro should both be around the Rs 4,500 mark.

Of Cells And Dells

Q I am going to take up an animation course for which I have decided to buy a laptop since I will be travelling. I need something powerful, something I can use for projects as well as something that will suffice for entertainment. Right now I am thinking of Dell's XPS M1210 and the Dell Inspiron 9400. The GPU is my main concern, though storage also figures.

Also, I am using a Nokia 6630, and am planning to upgrade. My budget is around Rs 20,000. Should I buy a Nokia N80 or wait for the N93 to become cheaper? I am looking for a good camera, music, and for Web browsing.

Bapan Mazumder

 If graphics is a major concern and price isn't, then you should consider the Inspiron 9400, which is available with a GeForce 7900GS graphics solution (not available on the XPS M1210), although this will cost you extra. A safer bet is a GeForce 7400 graphics solution that is available on both models, the XPS M1210 and the Inspiron 9400. Since you've mentioned multimedia as a possible use, I'd advise against the XPS M1210 because of its small screen.

The Inspiron 9400 will give you storage options all the way to 200 GB.

The N80 has a decent camera and good music playback quality. The real advantage for you will be integrated Wi-Fi, which means you can connect wirelessly to your laptop and surf.

Notebook Needs

Q I need to get myself a laptop that will be used to handle my e-mail, office paperwork, and presentations at conferences. I also need a webcam. My budget is around Rs 45,000.

Dr N N Chowdhury

 I'd suggest a Dell Inspiron 6400. Not only will you get one within Rs 45K, you will also get decent service and support. Dell's toll-free number is 1800-425-4026. You can also call 080-2506-8026. In terms of specifications, the Inspiron 6400 is configurable. A word of caution—it doesn't have an integrated webcam. HP's DV6000T has the option of a webcam; it offers similar specs. The DV6000T is also configurable, so your budget will be easily matched. Even if you cannot manage a Core 2 Duo within Rs 45,000, try to go with 1 GB of RAM. The same goes for the Inspiron 6400.

Nokia Connects

Q I want to buy a mobile for connecting my PC to the Internet. My budget is Rs 3,500 to 4,500. I am considering Nokia's 6030, referring to your test last year. But newer models like the Nokia 2626 also seem attractive. A camera is of no concern, but FM is a desirable feature.

Anil T K

 Nokia's 6030 is an old model now. Let's talk about the 6070, which should cost you around Rs 5,000. I'd suggest this model because it has a class 10 GPRS receiver. The Nokia 2626 in comparison has a class 6 GPRS receiver, and is therefore slower than the 6070. While this may not be noticeable while browsing the Internet now, the fact that your cell has a class 10 GPRS receiver may be of importance later. You'll also get a slightly higher-resolution screen and a little more inbuilt memory. You'll also get a VGA camera, even if you don't need it, and the phone has FM inbuilt. ■



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